# *Cold Pastoral*

## On the voice in the last two lines of Keats's "Ode on a Grecian Urn"

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No Greek urn answers to the one Keats describes. Readers who went looking for it in the British Museum found parts of several: the heifer led to sacrifice on the Parthenon frieze, which Keats saw among the Elgin Marbles in the spring of 1817, and the Bacchic dancers of the Townley Vase, with those of the Borghese Vase in the Louvre, known in London through engravings (Jack). The nearest thing to a single source is a sheet of paper. Keats traced an engraving of the Sosibios Vase, a marble krater signed by an Athenian sculptor of the first century BCE, from Henry Moses's book of antique vases, and the tracing survives (McDermott). The urn of the poem is a composite, assembled from marbles and from prints of marbles, and at the end it speaks.

Keats wrote the ode in May 1819. It was first printed in January 1820 in the *Annals of the Fine Arts*, a London magazine about painting and sculpture, and that summer he collected it in his third and last book of poems. The two printings differ in one mark of

punctuation, and much of what has been written about the poem since turns on that mark.

## The questions

The ode opens by naming its object three times, as a "still unravish'd bride of quietness," a "foster-child of silence and slow time" and a "Sylvan historian" (Keats, "Ode" 1–3). The names are a courtesy: the speaker wants the historian to tell its tale. "What men or gods are these? What maidens loth? / What mad pursuit? What struggle to escape?" (8–9). The urn does not answer, and for three stanzas the speaker answers for it, praising the "unheard" melodies of the painted pipes over heard ones (11–12) and a lover who will never reach the girl but will always love her.

The fourth stanza turns from the dancers to a procession, a priest leading a heifer "lowing at the skies" (33), and then to a town that is not on the urn at all, emptied of its people by the sacrifice and left silent "for evermore" (38). Here the questions stop being answerable even in principle. The town exists only because the procession has to have come from somewhere.

## The punctuation of the last lines

In the last stanza the speaker gives up questioning. The urn "dost tease us out of thought / As doth eternity: Cold Pastoral!" (44–45), and it will outlast this generation as "a friend to man, to whom thou say'st, / 'Beauty is truth, truth beauty,'—that is all / Ye know on earth, and all ye need to know" (48–50). In the 1820 volume the inverted commas close after "beauty," so the urn says five words and someone else says the rest. The *Annals* text has no inverted commas, and Stillinger records that neither have the transcripts made by Keats's friends. An editor has to choose, and the choice decides who says "that is all": the urn to mankind, the poet to his reader, or the poet to the figures on the urn.

The lines have had hostile readers. T. S. Eliot found the couplet "a serious blemish on a beautiful poem" (230), a statement that

was either untrue or one he could not understand. Cleanth Brooks answered that the words are "a speech 'in character'" (165), fitted to the urn that utters them, and set them beside Edgar's "Ripeness is all" in *King Lear*. His reading needs the 1820 punctuation: if the urn speaks only the five words inside the commas, the motto is the urn's, and the comment after the dash belongs to the poet who has listened to it.

## The letters

Keats had written about beauty and truth before he wrote about the urn. "What the Imagination seizes as Beauty must be truth—whether it existed before or not," he told Benjamin Bailey in November 1817 (Keats, *Letters* 41). A month later, walking home from the Christmas pantomime, he named the quality he thought a poet most needed:

> I had not a dispute, but a disquisition, with Dilke upon various subjects; several things dove-tailed in my mind, and at once it struck me what quality went to form a Man of Achievement, especially in Literature, and which Shakspeare possessed so enormously—I mean Negative Capability, that is, when a man is capable of being in uncertainties, mysteries, doubts, without any irritable reaching after fact and reason. (Keats, *Letters* 48)

Read with the letter beside it, the couplet is less a doctrine than a refusal. The urn has answered none of the speaker's questions about who the figures are or where the town stands. What it offers instead is a sentence that cannot be checked, and the poet's comment accepts that this is all the urn will give. The speaker who began by demanding a tale ends content with half knowledge, which is the state the letter asks a poet to bear.

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